

Order to Shipment

How it works today, how it would work, and what it saves · 23 September 2026

The short version. An order is handled by three people and re-typed into three systems before the customer hears anything. The order already exists digitally the moment sales enters it — everything after that is moving paper around a building and copying numbers between screens.

At **45 to 95 orders a day**, small per-order savings compound into most of a full-time role.

The numbers we are working with

Month (2026)	Orders	Working days	Orders per day
January	900	20	45.0
February	1,423	20	71.2
March	2,064	23	89.7
April	1,990	21	94.8
May	1,403	20	70.2
June	1,506	22	68.5

Average **2.2 lines per order**, with the largest at 25. Busy months run close to **90 orders a day**. Every minute saved per order is roughly **1.5 hours a day** at that volume.

How it works today

Orders arrive three different ways, and two of them start on paper.

Route 1 — phone or customer PO

#	Step	Who	Est. min
1	Takes the call or PO, enters a sales order	Sales	—
2	Prints the sales order	Sales	0.5
3	Walks it to shipping	Sales	0.3
4	Sorted into FedEx, Freight or Customer Pickup	Hannah	0.2
5	Re-types the order into FedEx or the freight portal	Hannah	3.0
6	Verifies the address against the PO, when one is attached	Hannah	1.5
7	Prints labels and shipping documents	Hannah	0.5

#	Step	Who	Est. min
8	Peels the top off the label, sticks it to the paperwork	Hannah	0.5
9	Puts it in the pile for the bookkeeper	Hannah	0.2
10	Types the tracking number into the system	Sharon	1.5
11	Sends the invoice to the customer	Sharon	1.0

Roughly **9 minutes per order** of handling, *before* anyone picks or packs anything. These are estimates — see the note on measuring them.

Route 2 — Amazon

Orders arrive from Amazon, are **printed**, then **typed by hand into QuickBooks**, then handed to Hannah. So Amazon orders never exist in USSCOS at all, and the same details are keyed twice before anyone picks them.

These also carry a **same-day ship obligation**, and nothing in the current process marks them as more urgent than anything else in the pile. They are urgent because someone recognises the printout.

Route 3 — customer pickup (CPU)

The packing list goes into a file holder, the clerk collects it and pulls the order into the CPU area. No carrier, but the same paper trail — and **no record of who collected it or when**, which matters when a customer says it never arrived.

Coming soon — the website

Products will be pushed to a website and those orders will come into USSCOS directly. Worth building the channel model to expect it now rather than retrofitting a fourth route later.

And separately — picking and packing

- Orders are gathered, **counted by hand across all of them**, then someone walks the warehouse to pick.
- There is no pick list, so the counting is repeated mentally every time.
- Packing is unverified. **Wrong items get packed and shipped**, which comes back as a return and puts the stock count out.
- Orders that cannot ship yet are **a physical pile Hannah manages**, and she **repeatedly checks whether product has arrived** to release them.

Where the time actually goes

Bottleneck	What it costs	Fixed by the ERP?
The same data typed three times	Order into USSCOS or QuickBooks, again into FedEx, tracking back again	Yes
Paper walks the building	Sales to Hannah to Sharon, three handoffs per order	Yes
The bookkeeper is a queue	Nothing reaches the customer until Sharon works through her pile	Yes
Address checked only sometimes	Only when a PO happens to be attached, and by eye	Yes
Backorders live in a pile	Hannah polls for arrivals rather than being told	Yes
No pick list	Quantities counted by hand across orders, repeatedly	Yes
One trip per order	The same rack visited many times a day	Yes
Packing is unverified	Wrong shipments, returns, and stock that no longer matches	Yes
Amazon keyed by hand	Printed, re-typed, and invisible to USSCOS	Yes, with the Amazon link
Deciding the carrier	Still a judgement about cost and service	No — stays human
Loading the truck	Physical work	No

How it would work

Same people, same building. The order stops being paper and the copying stops.

#	Step	Who	Change
1	Order entered, or pulled in automatically from Amazon	Sales / system	Amazon keying gone
1b	Amazon orders land labelled and flagged urgent, at the top of the queue	System	Same-day protected
2	Order appears in the shipping queue the moment it is confirmed	—	No printing, no walking
3	Shipping builds a pick list across several orders at once	Hannah	One trip, not many
4	Picker scans each item; wrong or excess is refused at the shelf	Picker	Wrong picks stopped
5	Packer rescans at the bench to confirm the carton	Packer	Wrong packs stopped
6	Customer PO shown on screen beside the address	Hannah	No paperwork to open
7	Carrier rated and label printed from the order	Hannah	No re-typing
8	Tracking captured automatically. Freight PRO arrives later, when the carrier raises the BOL	—	Step removed

#	Step	Who	Change
9	Invoice raised and emailed with tracking on it	—	Step removed
10	Stock deducted as it ships	—	Count stays true
11	Backorders release themselves when stock arrives	—	No more checking

Several pickers, one queue

There are several shipping people, and whether each gets their own pick list or everyone works one general list is still open. The usual answer avoids choosing:

- **One shared queue, and picking an order claims it.** Whoever starts an order holds it, and it disappears from everyone else's list.
- No one has to assign work in advance, and nobody picks the same order twice.
- A claimed order that goes quiet can be released back, so a person going home does not strand it.
- Progress is already stored per order rather than per person, so one picker can finish what another started.

Worth deciding after the pilot rather than before it — the right answer depends on whether pickers naturally work whole orders or split a trip between several.

And the orders that cannot ship

Today these are a physical pile that Hannah manages, checking repeatedly whether product has arrived. In USSCOS they become a list, worked out from stock rather than memory:

- Each order is checked against available stock — on hand, less what is already committed elsewhere.
- The order is marked fillable, partly fillable, or blocked.
- **The screen names the product holding it up**, because the question actually asked is "what are we waiting on".
- **A receipt releases the orders it unblocks.** Stock arriving is what tells Hannah, instead of Hannah going to look.

The same arithmetic answers production. Stock, less what is committed, against what is ordered. Read one way it says which orders cannot ship. Read the other, it says which paint to make — the problem of making stock we do not need while customers wait on stock we do.

What it saves

Step removed or shortened	Min saved	Why
Printing and walking the order	0.8	The order is already digital
Re-typing into FedEx or freight	2.5	Address, weight and service come from the order
Checking the address	1.0	PO shown beside it instead of opened
Label peeled and stapled to paper	0.7	Nothing to attach it to
Tracking typed into the system	1.5	Captured from the carrier
Invoice sent by hand	1.0	Sent on shipment
Counting quantities across orders	1.0	The pick list does the arithmetic
Total per order	~8.5	Conservative — excludes walking saved by batch picking

At this volume	Orders/day	If 8.5 min saved	If only 4 min saved
Quiet month	45	6.4 hrs/day	3.0 hrs/day
Typical	70	9.9 hrs/day	4.7 hrs/day
Busy month	90	12.8 hrs/day	6.0 hrs/day

Treat these as estimates, not a promise. They are built from the steps described, not from a stopwatch. **Time one normal day** — how long Hannah spends per order in FedEx, how long Sharon spends on tracking and invoices — and the real figure will be close to one of these columns. Even the pessimistic column is half a person a day.

The savings not in the table

- **Fewer wrong shipments.** Every one costs a return, a replacement, the freight both ways, and a stock count that no longer matches.
- **Customers told sooner.** Tracking goes out on shipment rather than when the pile reaches Sharon.
- **Backorders stop being watched.** The system releases them when stock lands.
- **Sharon stops being the bottleneck** and reviews exceptions instead of typing tracking numbers.

The wrong shipments

Wrong shipments happen **several times a week**. Taking that as three, it is roughly **150 a year**, and each one costs more than it first appears.

What a wrong shipment costs	Note
Freight out on the wrong goods	Already spent
Freight back	Usually ours
Freight out again on the right goods	Paid twice for one sale
Picking and packing a second time	Labour, twice
Admin — the call, the credit, the re-order	Sales and bookkeeping
The stock count goes wrong twice	Wrong item left, right item did not — and the return may never be recorded
The customer relationship	Not costed here, and not nothing

This is the strongest single argument for scanning. At 150 a year, even a conservative \$75 of hard cost each is over **\$11,000 a year** — before counting the inventory drift they cause or the customers they annoy. A scan at the bench refuses the wrong item before the carton closes, which is the only point where stopping it is cheap.

It also explains part of the inventory problem. Roughly 150 unplanned returns a year, arriving with no process to record them, is precisely the kind of leak that produces a count nobody can explain.

What it will not fix, and what to watch

Worth being straight about these — they decide whether the rollout succeeds.

- **Scanning only helps where barcodes exist.** Today: 38% of items have a retail barcode, 49% a case barcode. For the rest the SKU is typed. That works, but it is not instant — and prioritising barcodes on fast movers matters more than reaching every item.
- **A pick list is only as good as the stock figure.** If the count is wrong the list sends someone to an empty rack. This is why receiving, counting and returns come *before* the clever picking.
- **Wi-Fi in the racks.** If coverage drops where the paint is, scanning stalls. Worth walking the building with a device before buying several.
- **Someone still confirms the order.** Orders start as drafts and only reach shipping once confirmed. If that step is skipped they stay invisible — the digital equivalent of the paper never being walked over.
- **Carrier choice stays a judgement.** The system can rate and compare; deciding freight versus parcel is still a person.
- **Adoption is the real risk.** If scanning is slower than what people do now, they will work around it, and the count will rot exactly as it does today. Every screen has to be quicker than the paper it replaces.

What I would do, in order

Change		Why here
1	Stock movements first — receiving, shipping deduction, returns, adjustments	Everything else depends on the count being real
2	Opening physical count	Once there are screens to keep it true
3	Consolidated pick list, picked by scan	Biggest single time saving in the warehouse, and it stops wrong picks
4	Pack verification at the bench	Catches what picking missed, before it ships
5	Customer PO on the order, with an address-verified tick	Replaces opening paperwork, and makes the check consistent
6	FedEx labels and tracking	Removes the re-typing and the tracking hand-off entirely
7	Invoice and tracking emailed on shipment	Takes the bookkeeper off the critical path
8	Automatic backorder release	Ends the checking
9	Amazon orders pulled in automatically	Ends printing and double keying; also confirms shipment back to Amazon on time
10	Freight quotes from Kuebix	Last of the re-typing, and dependent on their API being enabled

Why this order and not the obvious one. The tempting start is FedEx and the pick list, because that is where the visible pain is. But a pick list built on a stock figure nobody trusts sends pickers to empty racks, and the crew stops using it within a fortnight. Get the count honest first and the rest lands on something solid.

Questions this raised

- **Where will the label printers go?** One at the pack bench per picker, or a shared printer — decides whether a label prints where the work happens or someone walks for it.
- **Own pick list per person, or one shared queue?** Recommendation above is a shared queue with claiming, but worth settling after the pilot.
- **Should a customer pickup be signed for?** There is no record today of who collected or when, which is awkward when an order is disputed.
- **Does Amazon need confirming back the same day?** It is fully manual now, so a missed confirmation is invisible until account health drops.
- **Who is the pilot group,** and when can they give it a full day with real orders?

Answered since the first draft: the website channel is coming and will feed USSCOS directly; Amazon is entirely manual today; wrong shipments run several times a week; customer pickup runs on a file holder and the CPU area; and the freight PRO number comes back from the carrier once they have entered the shipment to raise the BOL — so it arrives **after** the order ships, not with the label.

A note on figures from USSCOS. The system is still in testing, so order and stock counts inside it describe test data rather than the business. Live figures in this document come from imported QuickBooks history, which is real.